**Southern Highlands Whitlam 2025 Federal Election Feedback.**
**By Penny Newlove Southern Highlands Campaign Coordinator**

As the Southern Highlands Branch Campaign Coordinator for [redacted], I was at pre poll all day every day. I myself called the AEC and the Wingecarribee Shire Council on four or five occasions to report either inappropriate behaviour or illegal signage. Here is my account of what I saw happening at both Prepoll, polling day and the placement of corflutes throughout the community and at the polling booths during the election campaign.

## Bowral Prepoll Report - Senior Citizen Centre Corbett Gardens Bowral

### Volunteers behaviour

Bowral Prepoll was swamped by [redacted] Party volunteers. I counted between 30 & 40 most days. They stood in pairs at times blocking entry of voters on each of the seven park entry gates, something that has never been done before at this venue in past elections. They stood in packs throughout the main walkway to the polling booth entrance and throughout the park, again, something that has never been done before. Most of these volunteers displayed no knowledge of AEC rules on interacting with the public.
These volunteers were loud at all times and at times obnoxious to both voters and other volunteers. We were regularly bated with loud snide remarks about losing the election and about [redacted]. It was only that our volunteers' behaviour was mature and professional; ignoring these remarks saved, what could have turned into a confrontation.
I witnessed [redacted] Party volunteers displaying very passive aggressive behaviour, deliberately stepping in front of voters, blocking them from walking as they bombarded them with their "Friendly banter" and not letting them pass until they took a HTV from them. It felt menacing and crossed the line into voter harassment.
I also witnessed these volunteers loudly calling after voters who had not taken the HTV flyers, asking them why they didn't take their card? Quote, "Why didn't you take ours, you took theirs, don't you want to make Australia smile again? or c'mon you've got to take ours, that's not fair". I also heard some [redacted] Party volunteers calling after exiting voters, asking them who they voted for or saying, I hope you voted for the blue team.
Shouting out insults against other parties at passing voters was a constant tactic and using a Trump- like slogan, "Let's make Australia smile again or Let's make Australia happy again".
When the queues were long, I witnessed the volunteers from the [redacted] Party, [redacted], [redacted], [redacted] and the [redacted] all working the queue, badgering voters who most showed displeasure on their faces and clearly not interested, but too polite to say. Their facial expression and body language was ignored. I understand this is not illegal, but it did feel borderline harassment of voters and did not seem respectful.
Our volunteers received many negative comments and complaints from passing voters who often said they felt harassed by those in the blue tshirts or how ridiculous it was that there were so many of them. We felt really sorry for voters and what they had endure while running the gauntlet.

We suspected that these were not [redacted] party volunteers from the local Branches and during that first week of prepoll, in conversation would ask them where they were from and did they attend branch meetings? We were always told they were [redacted] party volunteers and always, claimed they lived in Moss Vale. Later said they were [redacted] party members bused in from other areas. At no point did they disclose they were members of the Brethren, until it became public knowledge and they no longer could hide it.

## Six Metre rule

This rule was constantly ignored by many volunteers and candidates.
I witness the [redacted] Party volunteers regularly entering this zone to hand out and interact with voters. I also witnessed [redacted]'s volunteers, [redacted] and the [redacted] Party volunteers constantly ignoring this rule. The AEC workers had to come out regularly to speak to volunteers who were in breach of this rule, but they continued to ignore the AEC and continued this practice.
The [redacted] Party Volunteers stood in a line, toes on the six metre line in front of the booth entry door, calling out to voters their slogans and bad mouthing [redacted] as they entered the polling booth and at times entering the zone to give a HTV to them even though they didn't want one, clearly not taking one from the 30 or so other volunteers handing out throughout the park.
This rule was even ignored by some candidates. Most afternoons, [redacted], an experienced [redacted] candidate, constantly stood in the 6-metre zone handing out and speaking to voters. He just seemed to not care about the rule.
On the second Thursday of prepoll, [redacted] paid a visit to prepoll. [redacted], even stood with [redacted] in the 6metre zone handing out HTV's and speaking with voters.
Another candidate [redacted] from the [redacted] also made a habit of constantly standing in this zone handing out HTV's and speaking to voters.

After it was disclosed that the [redacted] volunteer base came from the Brethren and that many complaints had been received about their behaviour, a new tactic arose. Free coffee and hot donuts for all volunteers. There were regular visits from the Brethren throughout the day handing out these freebies to all campaign volunteers and the passing voters. One has to wonder if this was a tactic to placate us and to stop future complaints.

During the two weeks of prepoll we saw how over worked the booth AEC officers were from the constant issues arising from the [redacted] volunteers, it must have been awful for them. They looked at myself and the [redacted] campaign manager with dread when they saw us coming. Towards the end of the first week I felt that my complaints had become annoying to them I was regularly told that things were out of their hands, which was probably true, and to phone head office. I understood that there were things that were out of their control, but because of that I felt very alone and deserted by the AEC. When phoning the AEC head office, we were listed to and phoned back with updates, but again the sheer number of complaints received about the [redacted] campaign left us alone without resolve, again allowing the [redacted] to receive the advantage of their inappropriate behaviour and illegal signage.

## Displaying of A-frames

* Swamping of the entire perimeter fence of Corbett Gardens with [redacted] Party [redacted] signs. These included a dozen or more of the illegal oversized (Rural property) corflutes placed on the picket fence and large wooden frames, constructed by the [redacted] party campaign, to display at height both the illegal size and standard corflutes.
The volunteers refused to remove these illegally placed and size corflutes, taking two days to remove them after the AEC and Wingecarribee Shire Council ordered them to remove them immediately. After finally taking down the corflutes, the signs were then left against the fence facing out, essentially still on display.
Walking past on my lunch break, I noticed this. I approached some of the volunteers standing on each gate and asked them to remove them as they are still on display, they claimed they didn't know how to. I asked if they could place the signs around the other way

so their backs were facing out, they did this. I then realised that these signs were placed in front of other candidates' legally placed signs.

*There was also several unauthorised [redacted] Party signs on display.

* The next day giant A-frames displaying these removed illegal oversized [redacted] Party corflutes were placed in the grounds of the polling booth on the walking paths and throughout the park. These signs took up most of the space of the pathway to the entrance of the booth blocking other (standard size) corflutes and making it difficult for others to display their signage. These giant A-frames felt dangerous and imposing. Several voters volunteered to me that they felt harassed by these signs and the amount of signage around the park.
The general feel of their prepoll campaign was to smother, dominate and obstruct. Simple things like the height of their standard A frames was clearly designed to block the view of the other candidates' A frames. They were made of solid plywood and taller than the normal a-frames, it just felt like a deliberate tactic. This unpleasant spirit was unlike anything I had witnessed and did not make for the usual collegian feel to prepoll.

*All towns and main roads of the Southern Highlands area of Whitlam, were covered in illegally placed [redacted] Party/[redacted] corflutes. These corflutes were placed on public property in large numbers. They were illegally placed on bridges, Railway property and public land. These corflutes were also displayed on many private properties and businesses such as large shops and car parks who hadn't given permission to the [redacted] Party to display.
Pedestrian refuge island grab rails had a corflute attached on each side, blocking view of pedestrians from drivers. Street signs on main roads had [redacted] corflutes attached to their poles. This included Stop and Give way signs, speed limit signs, pedestrian crossing signs and location/street signs. There was no consideration for either Wingecarribee Shire Council rules or AEC rules and definitely no care for the residents of Whitlam's safety.

WS Council had to remove these illegal signs, having to use employees from other departments to meet the demand. The next day after removal, these signs were placed back in all the above places that night.
Again the residents of Whitlam and their safety and the waste of Council resources was not a concern for the [redacted] Party and [redacted].

[redacted] Party - ignoring of WS Council request to remove marquee from gravel area in front of the Polling Booth entrance due to being a historic protected site. We were both ordered by a Council Inspector to remove our marquees.
Both the [redacted] and our party removed our marquees.
Two days later, the [redacted] ignored this request re-erecting their marquee on a daily basis until the end of prepoll.

## Polling Day

I was the coordinator of all the Southern Highlands booths. I was at the Moss Vale Civic Centre booth for most of the day. I also visited and phoned booth captains regularly throughout the day. All major booths booth captains reported the same behaviours as mentioned during prepoll at their polling booths.

All polling booth perimeter fences were completely covered by [redacted] Party/[redacted] signage, leaving none or very little space for other candidates to display their signage. The

amount of their corflutes and banners felt overwhelming and again, some voters reported to our volunteers that they felt harassed by the overkill.

All booth Captain's reported illegally placed signs on public land and on street signs on the streets surrounding each booth.
There were many unauthorised signs by Advance Australia on display around the polling booths. We had no recourse on the removal of these illegal signs. There was no-one from either the AEC or the WS Council who could remove them. As there was no remedy for removal, these illegal corflutes were left on display to the voters all day. Again, we were left feeling deserted, helpless and disadvantaged.

## General

These [redacted] Party/[redacted] volunteers, some who were experienced campaigners, chose to ignore the AEC rules, rules they were well aware of from past elections. Those who made up the numbers were mainly from the Brethren. They were more often loud and in the face of voters. They were ignorant to the general rules of volunteering at a polling booth, from handing out HTV's to the size and placement of corflutes and Aframes.
All these [redacted] Party volunteers ignored AEC rules and guidelines and conducted themselves in a disrespectful manner to both voters, other volunteers and our democratic voting system.
I feel this behaviour encouraged other volunteers from some of the minor parties and [redacted] to behave in a similar way, also ignoring the AEC rules. This led to the disrespecting of the voter's rights and our rights as fellow volunteers to have a safe space to work in.
As a volunteer sharing the space with them, our team of volunteers and I found the polling booths to be intimidating, stressful and exhausting. We were regularly bated with inflammatory comments, felt pushed out and fighting for space for Aframes and volunteer's places in the line. Everyday was stressful, intimidating and unpleasant.
Everyday there was a new issue to deal with. Whether it was because of constant and unpredictable changes to the rules of use of Corbett Gardens by Wingecarribee Shire Council due to the breeching of the rules by the [redacted]/[redacted] campaign team, or the behaviour of the [redacted] party and some minor parties and [redacted]'s volunteers and candidates or, at times, the lack of help or advise from the AEC both on premises or from their Head Office. We were left feeling alone and unsupported by the AEC and always at a disadvantage. We were forced to watch helplessly as AEC & WS Council rules were broken by these practices leaving us and other rule abiding campaign teams feeling unfairly disadvantaged, uncomfortable and stressed.
I have to say this was one of the most unpleasant and stressful pre-polls I have ever worked on; it is only on a par with the Voice Referendum, but for very different reasons. It was not a safe space for all volunteers, unless you were in a Blue t-shirt.
I can only imagine how the public must have felt as a voter attending this prepoll booth and the other booths on polling day. I do know as a resident of Southern Highlands how unpleasant it was living in Whitlam during this time.

I do not feel democracy was respected or met at this election.

Yours in [redacted]

Penny Newlove
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Snr Vice President of Whitlam [redacted]
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